

OPTIONAL SKIRMISHING RULE

Commanded shot before the main engagement

Daniel J. Berger • September 7, 2026 • Version 1.1

Purpose

This optional rule represents the loose exchange of fire by commanded bodies of musketeers before the main bodies became fully engaged. It adds limited probing and reaction fire without changing the normal combat system. A skirmish may create an opportunity, but another unit must be positioned to exploit it before the dice are rolled.

Optional Rule

1. Eligibility and timing

At the beginning of a friendly March Phase, each friendly leader may designate one ordered Foot unit of the same force (color) in its own or an adjacent hex. A Foot unit may not be designated twice. The designated unit must remain in its hex and may not otherwise move during that March Phase. For example, Rupert and Byron could designate one unit each (two total).

The player also designates an ordered enemy unit exactly two hexes away as the target. The target may not be in a close, train, or woods hex. Leaders, artillery pieces, and trains may neither initiate nor be targeted.

Skirmishing is permitted only during Game Turns 1–7 of the full game. It is not used in the Short Game. No skirmishes may be declared during a flash-rain turn [5.4].

An enemy unit may be selected as the target of no more than one skirmish in a March Phase.

2. Placing the marker

Place a **Skirmish** marker in an empty hex adjacent to both the designated Foot unit and its target. The marker represents the ground temporarily occupied by troops sent forward for the exchange; the Foot unit itself does not move.

Other friendly units may move through the marked hex normally, but may not end their movement there. The marker is not a unit and has no Zone of Control. Complete all ordinary movement before rolling any skirmish dice.

3. Resolving skirmishes

After all ordinary movement in the March Phase is complete, resolve declared skirmishes one at a time in any order chosen by the active player:

1. The skirmishing unit fires at its declared target, and the target makes a **Reaction Roll**. Roll one die for each unit. The skirmishing unit disrupts its target on a roll of **1 or 2**; the target disrupts the skirmishing unit on a Reaction Roll of **1**.
2. Record both results, but do not apply either result yet. The two attacks are simultaneous; a result suffered by one unit

never cancels its own fire.

3. Apply both recorded results simultaneously, then remove the marker.

A Reaction Roll is not always literal return fire. For Foot it represents return musketry; for Horse it may represent pistol or carbine fire, or a short countercharge. Horse may be a target, but may not initiate a skirmish.

4. After the exchange

The March Phase ends after all marked skirmishes have been resolved. No unit may move in response to a skirmish result. Proceed to the active player's Combat Phase normally. Thus, a unit already positioned to attack may exploit a newly disrupted enemy, but the active player cannot first see the result and then move up an attacker.

The marker does not create adjacency or require either unit to attack. All mandatory-attack requirements are determined from the units' actual positions at the beginning of the ensuing Combat Phase [9.0].

Skirmish Fire

Roll	Disrupts on
Skirmishing unit	1–2
Reaction	1

Rules References

March Phase movement: [8.0]. Disruption: [11.8]. Short Game: [16.0].

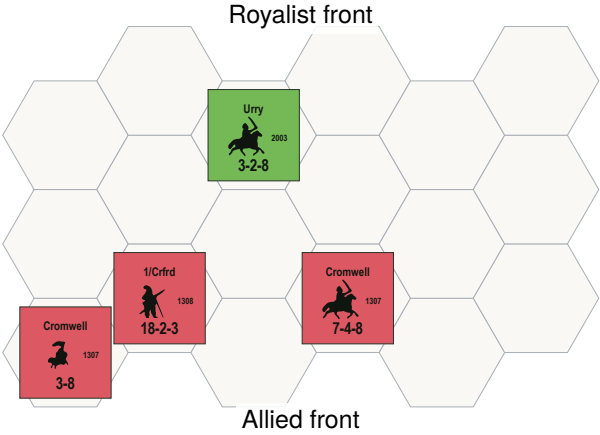
Design Intent

The idea here is to show some level of skirmishing at this scale while preventing unrealistic combined arms attacks, so any Horse waiting to exploit a disruption must be committed first. Most exchanges will do nothing, but occasionally one will open a useful opportunity. Think of this as an amalgam of skirmishing, advancing fire and retreating fire from something like GMT's Musket & Pike series.

Illustrated Example of Play

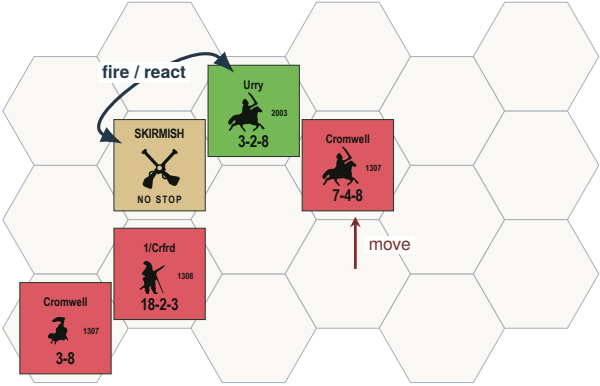
All illustrated hexes are clear terrain. At the beginning of an Allied March Phase, the **Cromwell** leader designates **1/Crfrd** to skirmish with **Urry**. Cromwell's Heavy Horse is nearby, but its movement must be committed before the skirmish dice are rolled.

Before: the Allied player plans the probe



The Cromwell leader designates 1/Crfrd, an ordered Foot unit of his force that begins adjacent to him. Urry is exactly two hexes away, with an empty hex between the two units, so it is an eligible target. The Allied player intends to place the Skirmish marker in that empty hex.

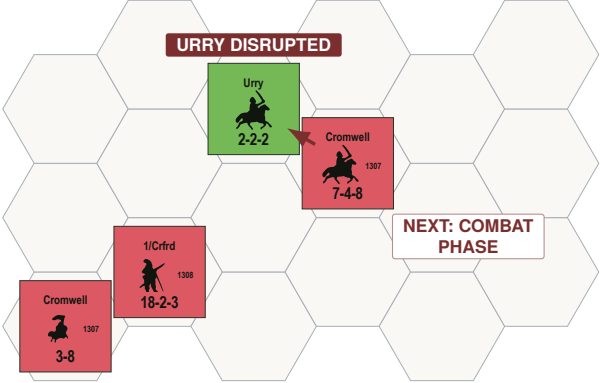
During: movement is completed, then fire is exchanged



The marker is placed in the intervening hex, while 1/Crfrd remains in its original hex. Other Allied units could pass through the marked hex, but none may end its movement there. Cromwell's Heavy Horse moves adjacent to Urry; all other Allied movement then ends. Both sides now roll:

- 1/Crfrd rolls **2**: Urry will be disrupted.
- Urry's Reaction Roll is **4**: no effect against 1/Crfrd.

After: apply the results and remove the marker



The recorded results are applied simultaneously: 1/Crfrd remains ordered and Urry is flipped to its disrupted side. The Skirmish marker is removed. The Allied Combat Phase now begins. Cromwell's Heavy Horse is already adjacent and must attack normally. It may exploit Urry's disruption because its charge was positioned before the successful skirmish roll.

The diagrams illustrate timing, not a historical deployment or exact map position.

Optional Cavalry Momentum Rule

Purpose

The cavalry fighting at Marston Moor was capable of carrying an entire wing away with it. This rule lets Heavy Horse gain ground after a successful combat, without adding a second attack or a full pursuit system.

1. Cavalry recoil

When a combat involving at least one attacking ordered Heavy Horse unit inflicts a Dd or Dx result on one or more ordered defending Horse units, apply the disruption and then retreat each newly disrupted defending Horse unit one hex. Heavy and Light Horse both recoil. A defending Horse unit that was already disrupted is eliminated normally and does not retreat.

The defending player chooses each retreat hex. It must be an adjacent, on-map hex that contains no unit and that the retreating Horse could legally enter by normal movement. The unit may not cross a prohibited hexside. Movement-point costs and enemy Zones of Control are ignored. If possible, the retreat hex may not be adjacent to any unit that participated in the attack. If no legal hex is available, the unit remains where it is, disrupted.

Any leaders stacked with a retreating unit may accompany it. Artillery pieces never retreat under this rule.

2. Heavy Horse advance

After all results of a combat, including cavalry recoil, have been applied, an ordered Heavy Horse unit that participated in the attack may advance into an adjacent hex vacated by a defending unit in that combat. This includes a hex vacated because all its defenders were eliminated, whether they were Foot or Horse, as well as a hex vacated by cavalry recoil. If more than one defending hex was vacated, one eligible Heavy Horse unit may advance into each vacated hex. No unit may advance more than once per Combat Phase.

An advance is optional, costs no movement points, and may enter an enemy Zone of Control. The advancing unit must obey normal terrain, hexside, and stacking restrictions. Any leaders stacked with it may accompany the advance.

An advancing unit cannot attack again or add its strength to an unresolved combat. Adjacencies and Zones of Control created by an advance do not require the players to declare additional combats during the current Combat Phase.

3. Charges

A charging Heavy Horse unit may advance if it remains ordered after the combat result. Make the advance before applying the automatic disruption required by [10.3]; the unit is then disrupted in its new hex. The directional Charge marker may be placed on a charging unit with its arrow pointing toward the defending hex.

Sequence

1. Apply the combat result.
2. Recoil newly disrupted defending Horse.
3. Advance eligible Heavy Horse into hexes vacated by elimination or recoil.
4. Disrupt ordered Heavy Horse that charged.

Historical Note

The historical record supports a more fluid treatment of cavalry. Goring's cavalry broke Fairfax's wing, with some squadrons pursuing or plundering while others turned against the Allied infantry. On the other flank, Cromwell and Leslie eventually drove off the Royalist horse; Cromwell then kept enough of his command together to cross the battlefield and attack the Royalist centre and Goring's scattered troops. The cavalry action produced sudden changes of position, even though the fight against Rupert's horse was itself hard-fought.¹

The recoil gives the winning side ground without treating every disruption as destruction. Foot does not recoil, but Heavy Horse may advance after eliminating it. Limiting the follow-up to Heavy Horse preserves the shock role of that arm. The prohibition on another attack keeps the result to a local breakthrough rather than allowing cavalry to roll up several units in one Combat Phase.

Rules References

Combat declaration: [9.0]. Heavy Horse charges: [10.2–10.3]. Combat results and disruption: [11.0–11.8].

¹See Historic England, "Battle of Marston Moor 1644" and Battlefields Trust, "The Battle of Marston Moor."

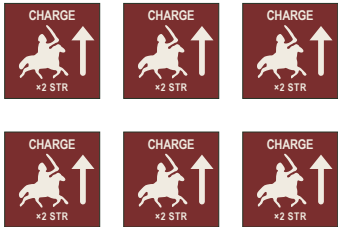
Printable Markers

Print this page at 100% scale and cut along the dark outer edges. The white gutters provide room for separate cuts. The Charge markers may be mounted on the reverse sides of the Skirmish markers. Rotate an Attack marker so its arrow points toward the defending hex. The two Turn Marker faces may likewise be mounted back-to-back.

Skirmish



Charge



Attack



Attack with Odds



Artillery Target



Turn Marker

